However, though many of the recommendations of the GoM have been implemented, the government has not taken a decision on the appointment of a CDS as yet; the ostensible reason being offered is lack of political consensus and unanimity amongst the services. Some of the important findings that have seen the light of day are the creation of the Integrated Defence Staff, the Strategic Forces Command, the tri-service Andaman and Nicobar Command, the defence intelligence agency and the defence procurement board, and enhancement of the delegated financial powers of the defence and finance ministries and the services for procurement of arms and equipment.

As an interim measure, an inter-service organization with a chief of Integrated Defence Staff (CISC), a three-star ranking officer (from one of the three services) heading it, has been created to assist the chairman of the chiefs of staff committee (COSC) in dealing with tri-service operational and administrative matters and other specific issues assigned by the COSC, besides streamlining the long-term integrated planning process, prioritization of acquisitions, and bringing about greater jointness in the armed forces. From my experience as the chairman, COSC, and as chief of army staff, the CISC set-up has been working satisfactorily. The effectiveness of the CISC and the exploitation of the full potential of the Integrated Defence Staff depends entirely upon the chairman and members of the COSC and the ministry of defence.

Notwithstanding this, the question that still needs to be addressed is whether there is a necessity for a chief of defence staff and if so, in what time frame? Further, will the higher direction of war in India be handicapped without one? These issues have engaged the attention of the political elite, the defence ministry, the national security set-up, strategic thinkers and scholars. Unfortunately, a lot of lip service is paid in this regard by some of them; these issues tend to get raised from time to time, more so at the time of retirement of some service chief or the other – a feeble attempt to get a four-star general's post created, in the hope that it might benefit the individual concerned! At the same time, I do believe that the parliamentary committees for defence, on more than one